

were collected directly from leased forts in exchange for goods, such as guns or alcohol, or ships plied the Gold Coast hoping to pick up a cargo of slaves from private dealers.

For the mercantile companies, shareholders, captains, and other traders involved, there appeared to be no moral qualms at all: slaves simply oiled the wheels of a well-organized and highly lucrative business. For example, by the 1780s the plantations of the French colony Saint-Domingue (Haiti) accounted for 60 percent of France's overseas wealth, supplying

Branding iron

When they were bought, all male slaves were forcibly branded with a hot iron as proof of ownership.

40 per cent of all the sugar and 60 percent of all the coffee consumed in Europe.

The middle passage

Slaves from the African coastal forts were packed on ships bound for South, Central, and North America—a journey called the “middle passage.” In the 16th–19th centuries, some

54,000 trade voyages were recorded. This peaked in the 1780s at 78,000 slaves a year, with half of them carried on British ships.

A typical middle passage journey took around 10 weeks. Each ship carried 140–600 slaves in appalling, cramped conditions. Men were chained together in a suffocatingly small space between the deck and the hold. Women were usually left unchained and were allowed on deck to help with the cooking. However, they risked constant sexual harassment and rape by the European crew.

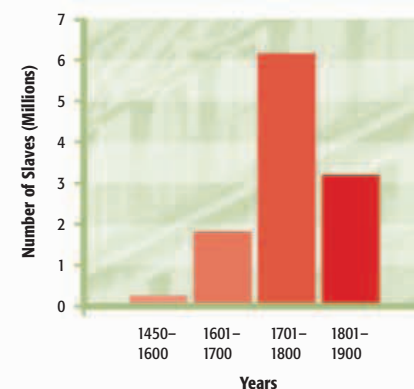
Hygiene on board ship was crude. Few ships were equipped to deal with bodily functions and, as they were shackled together, it was particularly hard for the men to avoid catching dysentery and smallpox—the two biggest onboard killers. After a month at sea, a slave ship stank of sweat, urine, feces, and vomit. It was said that a slave ship could be smelled two days before it actually arrived in a port.

Each morning, the slaves were dragged up onto deck and their shackles were inspected. Any slave who had died during the night was unchained and thrown overboard. Rations included boiled mash of horse beans and yams, biscuits, rice, plantain, and occasionally meat. One food bucket was usually shared among many, resulting in quarrels—and infection.

Captains and crew succumbed to disease and death as much as their cargo. In 1787, of the slave-ship crews that embarked from Liverpool in England, less than half returned alive.

Auctioned

Arriving in Brazil or the Caribbean islands, the slaves were sold at auction, then delivered to their new owners. This was often followed by a period of “seasoning”—about a year in which the slave either succumbed to disease or survived to live a life of human bondage and misery.



Number of slaves exported from Africa

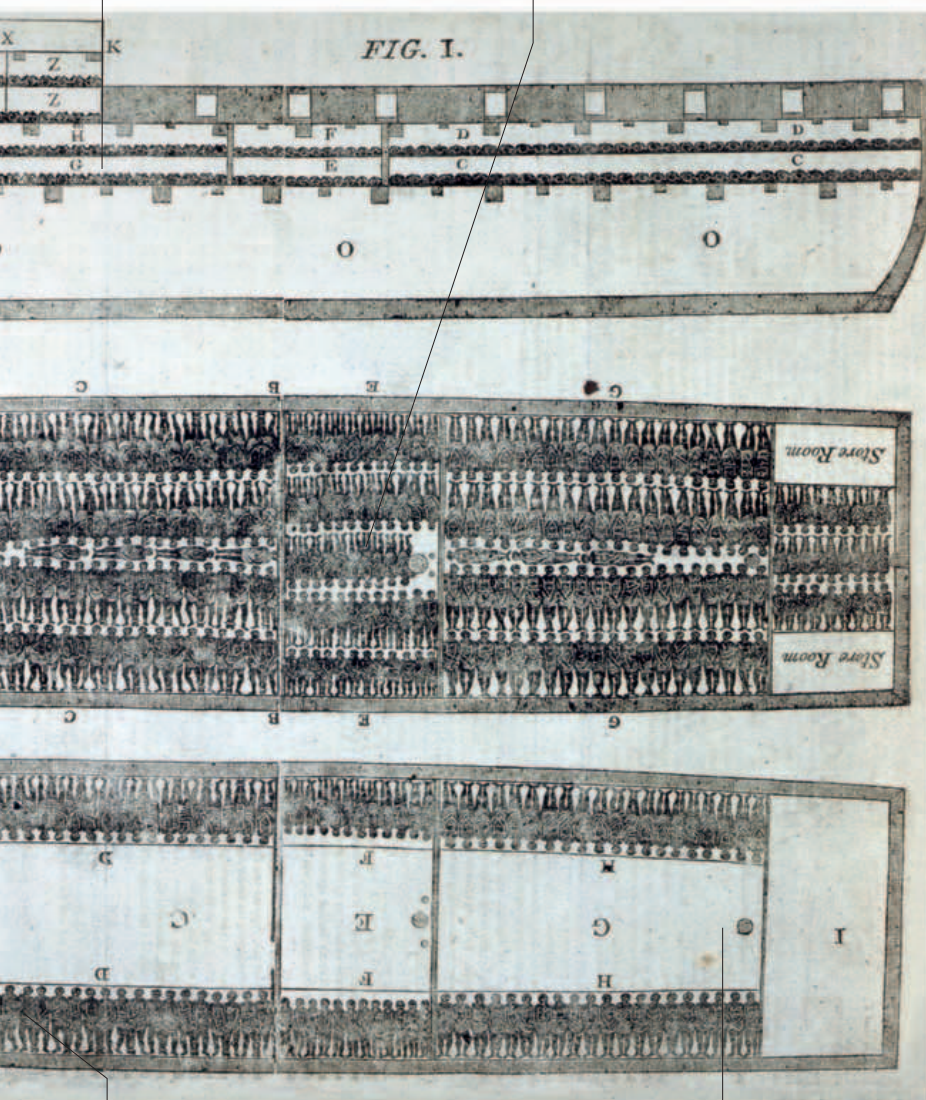
Records suggest that between 1450 and 1700, 2 million Africans were enslaved, rising to 6 million in 1701–1800. Accounting for those dying in transit to forts and on slave ships, the figure is probably closer to 12 million.

Slaves were shackled in rows

between the hold and the deck, lying on their back or sides. Each slave had only around 12 in (30 cm) space around them.

This diagram shows how 482 slaves

could be packed on board. This ship had previously carried as many as 609 slaves (351 men, 127 women, and 113 children).



Men were chained together

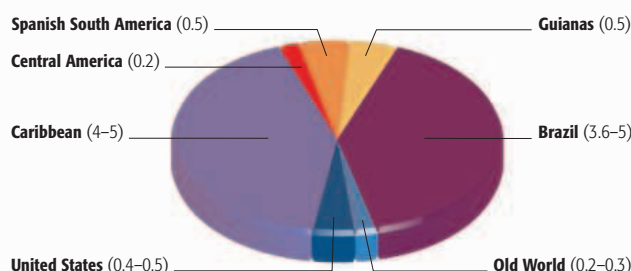
at the front of the boat; women were held in a separate area. Most transported slaves were between 16 and 45 years old.

Food and water

were stored in the hold below the slaves. Both food and water were rationed so there was enough to last the voyage. Any slave refusing to eat out of misery or rebellion was whipped.

Destination and number of slaves exported from Africa (in millions)

Most slaves bought by European traders were shipped to the Caribbean or Brazil, altering the population dynamics: by 1800, half of Brazil's population was of African origin.



AFTER

The slave trade was finally abolished in England in 1807, after years of campaigning by antislavery groups.

ANTISLAVERY CAMPAIGN

Thomas Clarkson, a leading antislavery protester in England, gathered evidence such as shackles and the oral accounts of former slave captains to publicize the horrors of the trade. The

fight gained momentum when it was taken up in parliament by William Wilberforce **308–09** >>>.

The Abolition of the Slave Trade Act was passed in England in 1807, followed by the **Emancipation Act of 1833**, which made owning slaves illegal. A string of legislation followed, with slavery abolished in the US in 1865, Cuba in 1886, Brazil in 1888, ending with Sierra Leone in 1927 and the Gold Coast in 1928.

ANTISLAVERY POSTER, BOSTON, 1851



SLAVERY TODAY

Modern-day human rights campaigners point out that the fight against slavery is far from over. It is estimated that there are **over 27 million slaves** in the world today, including people in forced labor, women and girls trafficked for work in the sex industry, and children kidnapped and forced to fight as soldiers.



CHAINED SLAVES IN ZANZIBAR